

Big Sur

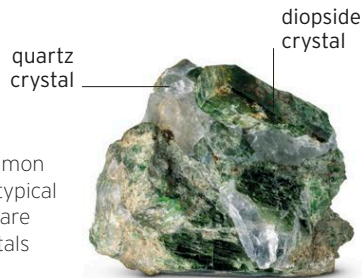
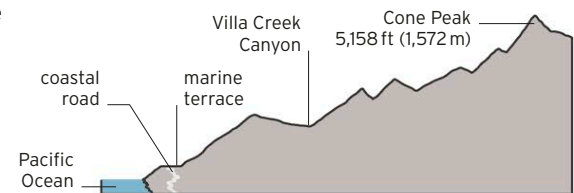
A long, rugged stretch of the central California coastline, with steep mountains and stunning views



Widely regarded as one of the most spectacular meetings of sea and land in the world, Big Sur is a roughly 100-mile- (160-km-) long section of undeveloped, wild coastline. Some sections of the hillsides just above the shoreline have been shaped into flat areas called marine terraces. These are former beaches lifted up by tectonic activity. A winding, narrow road extends down its length, affording spectacular views of the Pacific. The road and Big Sur in general, however, are susceptible to landslides as a result of wave action, weakening of the cliffs by faulting and fracturing, the destruction of vegetation by summer fires, and heavy winter rainfall.

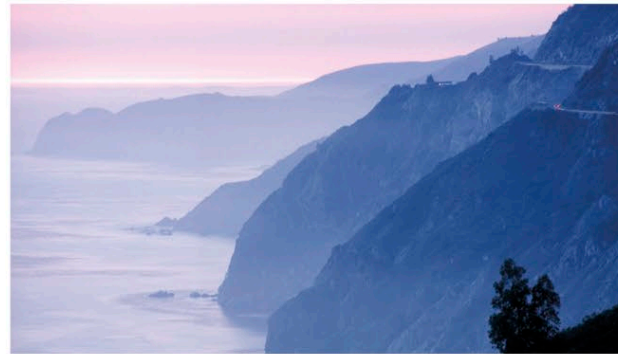
BIG SUR'S COASTAL SLOPE

One area of the Big Sur coastline, to the west of Cone Peak (in the Santa Lucia Range), has the steepest coastal slope in the U.S. outside Alaska and Hawaii. Here, the land rises sharply in a series of steps to Cone Peak, which is just 3 miles (5 km) from the Pacific Ocean.



▷ DEEP-GREEN JEWEL

The mineral diopside is common in the Big Sur region. Here, typical dull green diopside crystals are embedded with quartz crystals in a rock groundmass.



◁ MISTY HEADLANDS

Big Sur, seen here at sunset, winds in and out for much of its length, forming a near-endless array of small bays and headlands, often shrouded in mist.

▽ WAVE-BATTERED ROCKS

Around Big Sur's headlands, small rocky islets typically extend up to 330 ft (100 m) offshore. These are continuously pounded by waves surging in from the Pacific.

